



UNIVERSITY OF ALBERTA
FACULTY OF ARTS

ENGL 483, Section B1: Literary Sound Studies
Department of English and Film Studies
Winter Term 2025

Instructor: Professor Michael O'Driscoll

Office: HC 3-29

Zoom Room: <https://us02web.zoom.us/j/6354152761>

Office Hours: In Person Mondays 2:00-3:00pm. Virtual: Thursdays 2:00-3:00pm.

E-mail: mo@ualberta.ca (Please note: I do not respond during evenings or weekends.)

Course Location and Time: MWF 1:00-1:50 HC 2-34

Learning Management System: eClass

Teaching Assistant (AVAnnotate): Samantha Turner turnersam@utexas.edu

Teaching Assistant (Web Anthology): Catalina Torres Benjumea torresbe@ualberta.ca

Land Acknowledgement

The University of Alberta respectfully acknowledges that we are situated on Treaty 6 territory, traditional lands of First Nations and Métis people.

Visit [Native Land Digital](#), a beautiful and informative site that can help you understand more about traditional territories here in Alberta and around the world.

This is a course about listening. Active and ethical listening is essential to fulfilling meaningful commitments to social justice and decolonization. They're also essential to a supportive classroom environment.

Course Description

This advanced undergraduate seminar will redirect the attention of students of literature from the print text of dominant visual culture to often overlooked audio objects of literary creation and performance. Our critical approach to listening to literature will take place at the intersection of literary studies, sound studies, and the digital humanities in establishing the foundations for audile techniques, or listening practices, that inform a critical methodology of audiotextual analysis. Fundamental to such an endeavour will be: 1) the development of a critical vocabulary for hearing and listening to literature; 2) an appreciation of the history of audio technologies and the ways in which those technologies have shaped our understanding of listening as a phenomenological experience; 3) a political and historical contextualization of the disciplinary privilege of sight over sound; 4) a survey of key moments in recorded literary history, including late nineteenth-century acoustic-era recordings, the Caedmon poetry archive of the 1930-50s, the emergence of poetry reading cultures alongside magnetic tape recording

technologies, and more recent experiments in the creation of literary audio signals. Those more recent examples of born-digital audio experiments will be read alongside theories of resistant, critical listening. The assignments undertaken by students will focus on practices of engaged, critical listening, such as guiding short in-class listening practices and creating a short-form podcast that I call a “Sound Bite.” We will also engage with the cutting-edge technology of “AVAnnotate,” a web-based platform for sharing and curating annotations of audiovisual materials held at libraries, archives, and museums. We will conduct an iterative series of assignments that will lead students through hands-on, experiential engagement with the application, resulting in a class production of an anthology of annotated literary performances.

Course Format

This is an in-person course, meeting for 50 minutes, three times per week for the duration of the term. Our time together will include lectures & discussions, workshops, and student-led presentations on a weekly basis.

Textbooks

Most of our readings and listenings are freely available through the eClass course site. The following items can be purchased at the bookstore or elsewhere. (I encourage you to support our local independent bookstores, such as [Audreys](#) and [Magpie Books](#).)

Required Print Texts

Billy-Ray Belcourt *This Wound is a World* (for purchase at UA Bookstore)

Shima Robinson (aka Dwemminnem) *The Bellow Project*. (This is pending availability.)

Required Audio Texts

Billy-Ray Belcourt *This Wound is a World* (for purchase on Audible or other service)

Shima Robinson (aka Dwemminnem) & Damned Magpies [The Bellow Project](#). (This is available for free on Bandcamp; however, if you are able and willing to purchase the digital album and support the author, I'd encourage you to do so.)

Required Technology

Our weekly Wednesday Workshops will serve you best if you are able to bring a laptop to class; if not, a tablet or phone will do and you can complete the activity later at a desk top station if need be. If you have any issues with this, please let me know.

Important Dates

First Day of Class: January 6, 2025

Add/Delete Date: January 17, 2025

50% Withdrawal Date: February 5, 2025

Withdrawal Date: April 2, 2025

Last Day of Class: April 9, 2025

Final Exam Date: n/a

Lecture Schedule and Assigned Readings/Listenings

Please see our eClass site for full details.

Components of Course Grade:

Component	Weighting	Date
Participation	10%	Ongoing
Guided Listening Practice	10%	To Be Scheduled
Soundbite	20%	February 12
AVAnnotate Workshop	5%	February 26
AVAnnotate Case Study	10%	March 12
AVAnnotate Project Completion	20%	March 26
AVAnnotate Reflective Essay	20%	April 7
AVAnnotate Exit Survey	5%	April 9

Participation:

Participation is based on attendance, evident preparation for class, timely completion of assigned tasks, and contributions to discussions and other activities. Come to our class prepared by having completed the required readings and listenings. In our classroom space you are expected to be attentive, generous, and respectful.

Guided Listening Practice:

A “guided listening practice” is a shared encounter in which the guide (that’s you!) leads the class in attending to a particular sound event that they have selected for our consideration. That sound event can be shared through a digital audio recording (maximum 5 minutes duration, either found or created by you) or any sounding object (eg. musical instrument, music box, typewriter, bell, etc.) of the guide’s choosing. The listening practice should be no more than 15 minutes in length and should include the following elements: 1) background information or narrative about the sound event we will experience together; 2) two or three pre-listening questions that help to us to attend in ways that will shape our listening experience and reflect on that experience; 3) the

sounding of the recording or object; 4) a guided discussion following our listening experience in which the guide directs the conversation and responds to questions from other class members. This should be treated as an *informal* presentation. You can work from notes, but please do not prepare a script to be read. It is helpful if you can find ways to connect our guided listening experience to other issues, readings, and listenings we have shared in the class. [You can sign up for a listening practice date here](#). Three listening practices will take place each Friday, beginning in Week Two. You might be tempted to defer your presentation to later in the term, but I strongly advise you take this on early if that's possible for you.

Soundbite:

A “soundbite” is a short recording of no more than 4 minutes duration. The recording should include at least one short, recorded sound (in addition to your own voice) that you incorporate into your presentation as an example for analysis or an illustration of an idea. At its best, a soundbite will focus on a central argument, question, or problem that you would like to address through sonic engagement. The genre of your short recording might be an audio essay, a dialogue, a guided field recording, an investigative report, an interview, an audio collage—whatever you feel allows you to best focus your ideas. There is free and easy to use software that will allow you to produce this recording (Audacity and Zoom are readily available examples), and we will devote one class workshop to discussing best practices when it comes to scripting and sound production as well as help you to troubleshoot technological issues if need be. The point behind this is that sound production and sound editing are *audile techniques*, and users often remark that learning these skills can impact their own sense of attunement to the sound objects under consideration.

AVAnnotate Workshop:

This assignment will require that you attend our AVAnnotate Workshop on Wednesday, February 26 and Friday February 28 when our AVAnnotate expert will join the class to help you get started on your project. You'll complete the process of signing into AVAnnotate and creating a GitHub account. This will be an important opportunity for you to learn about the web platform that will be central to our iterative annotation assignment for the balance of the term. If you are unable to attend on this date for any reason (hopefully a legitimate one!), please speak with me and we will provide you with an alternative way to get started on this project.

AVAnnotate Case Study:

For your AVAnnotate Project, you will be required to identify a literary performance (or a portion of one) of no more than five minutes in length that you will subject to annotation. We will read about annotation as a practice, consider various examples, discuss methods and objectives of annotation in class, and review possible approaches to your project. For this assignment, you are asked to identify your object of study, provide a link to that digital audio object, and make a case for its use in the AVAnnotate environment. You will be asked to address three questions in particular: 1) why does this object lend itself to annotation? 2) what critical or theoretical lens will inform your analysis of the object? 3) what is the objective of your annotative practice? This essay

must be approximately 500 words in length. I will provide a range of objects you might use for this assignment, or you may choose your own.

AVAnnotate Project Due:

Your AVAnnotate Project is due on March 24th. To complete the assignment, you must finalize your annotations and send me an active link to your GitHub site that features your finished project. Send that link by submitting a document with the link to this eClass assignment.

AVAnnotate Reflective Essay:

But you're not done yet! For this assignment, you're asked to complete an essay of approximately 1500 words in length in which you introduce your annotations to your reader/listener and make a case (with reference to at least three of our readings this term or other scholarly essays that comment on the poem) for an analysis of the audiotext that draws from your observations on its characteristics. You might, in doing so, also provide an overview of your AVAnnotate project, argue for the approach you've taken to those annotations, and consider the affordances and challenges of your approach. The essay should include a bibliography and be formatted in MLA Citation style. For submission, the essay must be submitted on eClass. After you have received feedback from me and **made any necessary corrections**, you must upload the final version of your essay to your AVAnnotate site to serve as an introduction to your work. Your final grade will be confirmed after you have completed that upload as well as the AVAnnotate Exit Survey we will conduct in our last class.

AVAnnotate Exit Survey:

And you're still not quite done! For this last task, you will receive an email from the professor directing you to an online Google Form survey. The survey will require about 20 minutes to complete, and will address your experience with using AVAnnotate as a learning tool. Your answers will be anonymized and used to inform future developments of the AVAnnotate platform and future uses of the tool in classroom settings.

You will have an opportunity to complete this survey in our last class on Wednesday, April 9th or, if you are unable to attend that class, will be able to complete it by no later than the end of day, Friday, April 11th, online and from a location of your choosing. Please be as fulsome as possible in articulating your responses.

Grading: Student grades are unofficial until they have been approved by Arts Faculty Council or delegate.

Grade Scale:

Excellent	A +	4. 0	96-100
	A	4. 0	91-95

	A-	3. 7	86–90
Good	B +	3. 3	81–85
	B	3. 0	76–80
	B-	2. 7	72–75
Satisfactory	C +	2. 3	68–71
	C	2. 0	63–67
	C-	1. 7	59–62
Poor	D +	1. 3	55–58
Minimal Pass	D	1. 0	50–54
Fail	F	0. 0	0–49

Policy for Late Assignments:

With the exception of the in-class presentation, assignments must be submitted through eClass by midnight on the date assigned. Late assignments will be subject to a 5% reduction for each day or partial day of late submission, including weekends. Exceptions will only be made if the student provides an *acceptable* explanation and *advance* notice of the delay.

Deferral of term work is a privilege and not a right; there is no guarantee that a deferral will be granted. Misrepresentation of facts to gain an unfair academic advantage over other students is a violation of section 5.a in the [Student Academic Integrity Policy](#).

Student Responsibilities:

Academic Integrity: The University of Alberta is committed to the highest standards of academic integrity and honesty. Students are expected to be familiar with these standards regarding academic honesty and to uphold the policies of the University in this respect. Students are particularly urged to familiarize themselves with the provisions of the *Student Academic Integrity Policy* and the *Student Conduct Policy* (on the [University of Alberta Policies and Procedures Online](#) (UAPPOL) website) and avoid any behaviour which could potentially result in suspicions of cheating, plagiarism, misrepresentation of facts and/or participation in an offence. Academic dishonesty is a serious offence and can result in suspension or expulsion from the University.

All students should consult the website of the [Office of Student Conduct and Accountability](#).

Instructors are required to report potential violations of the *Student Academic Integrity Policy*.

ChatGPT and Similar Chatbots: The goal of most writing assignments you will be asked to carry out in the context of Department of English and Film Studies courses is to encourage you to develop and enhance the skills required for critical analysis, identifying persuasive evidence for your claims, formulating ideas, and communicating them clearly. Presenting material generated with the assistance of ChatGPT or any other AI as your own deprives you of the opportunity to learn and practice these skills on your own behalf. Naturally, too, it is pointless for an instructor to evaluate writing that you did not produce. For these reasons, the Department enforces the UofA's [Student Academic Integrity Policy Appendix A: Academic Misconduct](#), which defines contract cheating as “using a service, company, website, or application to ... complete, in whole or in part, any course element, or any other academic and/or scholarly activity, which the student is required to complete on their own” (2). Students who submit work generated by a website or application as their own writing will be reported to the Associate Dean (Undergraduate) in the Faculty of Arts. When the Associate Dean (Undergraduate) has determined that cheating and/or plagiarism has occurred, a number of sanctions can be imposed, such as lowering a grade, or, in rare cases, suspension or even expulsion from the University.

Students who want to strengthen their academic skills and learn more on topics such as note-taking, time management, and academic integrity are encouraged to explore [The Academic Success Centre](#).

Recording of Lectures: Audio or video recording, digital or otherwise, of lectures, labs, seminars or any other teaching environment by students is allowed only with the prior written consent of the instructor or as a part of an approved accommodation plan. Student or instructor content, digital or otherwise, created and/or used within the context of the course is to be used solely for personal study, and is not to be used or distributed for any other purpose without prior written consent from the content author(s).

Learning and Working Environment:

The Faculty of Arts is committed to ensuring that all students, faculty and staff are able to work and study in an environment that is safe and free from discrimination and harassment. It does not tolerate behaviour that undermines that environment.

All students should review the *Student Conduct Policy* (on the [University of Alberta Policies and Procedures Online](#) (UAPPOL) website). If you are experiencing harassment, discrimination, fraud, theft or any other issue and would like confidential advice and information, please contact any of these campus services:

- [Office of Safe Disclosure & Human Rights](#): A safe, neutral and confidential space to disclose concerns about how the University of Alberta policies, procedures or ethical standards are being applied. They provide strategic advice and referral on matters such as discrimination, harassment, duty to accommodate and wrong-doings. Disclosures can be made in person or online using the [Online Reporting Tool](#)
- [Sexual Violence Supports](#): - It is the [policy](#) of the University of Alberta that sexual violence committed by any member of the University community is prohibited and constitutes misconduct. The University takes seriously its responsibility to reduce sexual and gender-based violence through a culture of consent, gender inclusivity, anti-oppression and support, and to respond to misconduct or conditions that allow, facilitate, or give rise to sexual and gender-based violence.
- [University of Alberta Protective Services](#): Peace officers dedicated to ensuring the safety and security of U of A campuses and community. Staff or students can contact UAPS to make a report if they feel unsafe, threatened, or targeted on campus or by another member of the university community. For non-emergency dispatch, call 780-492-5050. For lost and found, call 780-492-2943. **In an emergency, call 911.**

Student Resources:

[The University Calendar](#) is one of the principal sources of U of A policy information for students. It includes admission requirements and deadlines, academic regulations, programs of study, academic standards, degree requirements, and University policies for both undergraduate and graduate students.

[The Student Service Centre](#) provides students with information and access to services to support academic, financial, mental, and physical well-being.

[First Peoples' House](#) provides an environment of empowerment for First Nations, Métis, and Inuit learners to achieve personal and academic growth.

[The Academic Success Centre](#) provides professional academic support to help students maximize their academic success and achieve their academic goals. They offer appointments, advising, group workshops, online courses, and specialized programming year-round to students in all university programs, and at all levels of achievement and study.

[Writing Services](#) offers free one-on-one writing support to students, faculty, and staff. Students can request a consultation for a writing project at any stage of development. Instructors can request class visits and presentations.

Under the [Discrimination, Harassment and Duty to Accommodate Policy](#), the Office of the Dean of Students coordinates academic accommodations for prospective and current students with documented disabilities affecting mobility, vision, hearing, learning,

and physical or mental health. The provision of academic accommodations helps to remove structural barriers that these students encounter in academic environments in order to facilitate equivalent learning opportunities for these students. [Accommodations and Accessibility](#) promotes an accessible, inclusive, and universally-designed environment at the University of Alberta.

[Health and Wellness Support for Students](#) outlines the mental and physical health resources which are offered on-campus and in the community.

[The Office of the Student Ombuds](#) is a confidential service which strives to ensure that university processes related to students operate as fairly as possible. They offer information, advice, and support to students, faculty, and staff as they deal with academic, discipline, interpersonal, and financial issues related to student programs.

The [Campus Food Bank](#) is an independent charity supporting University of Alberta students, faculty, staff, and alumni; it is located in SUB 1-81.

The UofA's Student Union [lists opportunities](#), including job postings, volunteer opportunities, and scholarships, grants, and other awards.

The [Need Help Now](#) webpage offers contact information for a variety of supports if you are in immediate need of mental health and wellness support. You can also call the 24-hour Distress Line: 780-482-4357 (HELP).

Disclaimer: Any typographical errors in this syllabus are subject to change and will be announced in class and posted on eClass. The date of the final examination is set by the Registrar and takes precedence over the final examination date reported in this syllabus.

Policy about course outlines can be found in [Evaluation Procedures and Grading System](#) in the University Calendar.

Copyright:

Michael O'Driscoll, Department of English and Film Studies, University of Alberta. 2024.